# When Democracy Turns Against Liberalism

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The number of democratic systems worldwide peaked in the early 2010's and has since declined (Our World in Data). For a generation raised on Fukuyama's claim that liberal democracy was the "end point of mankind's ideological evolution" (Fukuyama, 1989), this trend demands explanation. The instinctive conclusion is that democracy is in crisis. This essay accepts the verdict but contests its meaning. Crisis has its roots from the Greek *Krisis*: not a catastrophe but a turning point, the moment at which two paths separate and only one leads to recovery (Grasso, 2022). Understood this way, the present crisis facing democracy is not its collapse. It is the point at which democracy and liberalism – fused in the post-1945 settlement and triumphant after 1989 – have come apart.

Democracy is in crisis. The threat is not authoritarian seizure from without; it is democracy turning, from within and by its own hand, against the liberal order it once carried. This distinction is the essay's central claim. Zakaria warned as early as 1997 that electoral democracy and constitutional liberalism were separable, which the latter was the more fragile achievement (Zakaria, 1997). The dominant "democratic backsliding" framework (Bermeo, 2016) describes the mechanism of incremental, legal erosion of checks and balances precisely but mistakes its meaning. It treats liberal procedure as democracy itself and so reads the dismantling of liberal constraints as democracy under attack. But the cases of Hungary, Turkey, India, and increasingly the United States are not cases of democracy failing. They are cases of democracy functioning — electorates choosing, repeatedly and decisively, to dismantle the liberal order. Therefore, an honest diagnosis must come after this distinction: liberals no longer face the question of how to defend democracy from authoritarians, but what to do when democracy itself chooses against liberalism.

Three dynamics advance this essay's claim. First, the erosion of public trust creates social demand for strong leadership; second, elected strong leaders exploit this legitimacy crisis to hollow out democratic institutions from within; and third, a shifting international environment reduces external constraints on such behaviour. The sum of these dynamics leads to backsliding but the engine is democratic not authoritarian. And that is what makes it a crisis in the original sense: a fork at which liberalism's recovery is no longer guaranteed.

## Eroding Trust

The first dynamic is a collapse of public trust that converts democratic participation from a remedy into a grievance. A loss of public trust makes citizens more willing to support leaders who bypass democratic norms. From this flows democratic erosion. When governments fail to deliver security, stability, or prosperity, citizens begin to see democratic participation as ineffective. Voting shifts into a "meaningless ritual" (Ero & Mutiga, 2024). As a result, this opens a space for populist or authoritarian appeals. This pattern is visible across distinct regional contexts. Viktor Orbán did not consolidate power against the people's will; he was clearly enabled by it. He had popular support. Erdogan, in Turkey, made use of cultural and social cleavages to convince much of the electorate that his rivals were not mere alternatives but threats to the 'Turkish way of life'. This circumstance was harder to resist as erosion in both cases was incremental and legal. Here, Bermeo's backsliding model failed to recognise that cases of democratic majorities actively choosing to dismantle the liberal constitutional

order exist. The crisis is shown not to be the failure of democracy — it is that of liberalism. Mounk (2018)'s "undemocratic liberalism" showed this problem in reverse: where technocratic liberals once governed without the people, populist majorities now govern against liberal norms. The latter is best understood as an abundance of democracy rather than its death. Runciman (2018) later extends: in mature democracies, the greater threat is not violent overthrow but the slow erosion of democratic vitality from within — citizens disengaged, institutions sclerotic, and self-correction mechanisms quietly failing. Thus, the uncoupling of liberalism from democracy is as much a symptom of democratic fatigue as of populist insurgency.

In cases of sweeping institutional failure, a government's legitimacy collapses more quickly. The Sahel states of Africa (Mali, Niger, and Burkina Faso) have seen successful military coups not so much because of a pitched battle between the forces of democracy and those of authoritarianism, but because civilian governments have rarely managed to discharge the basic function of the state. These coups do not themselves cause a democratic crisis. Instead, they are a symptom of deeper political dysfunction (Ero and Mutiga, 2024). Taken together, we see that through the emergence of grievance politics (Hett, 2026), humiliation and frustration among voters provide fertile ground for authoritarian appeals. Declining trust creates the conditions for the subversion of the democratic system. Leaders are then able to hollow out institutions and use democracy against itself.

**Hollowing-out Institutions**

The second dynamic converts that demand into institutional fact: elected leaders use legal means to dismantle the checks that constrain them. As legitimacy wanes and public trust erodes, the environment is ripe for leaders to hollow out democracy from within. Bermeo (2016) most often identifies this process in the form of executive expansion. Elected leaders gradually increase their own power by legal means, undermining checks and balances, packing courts, limiting opposition and media, and holding elections without any real competition (Bermeo, 2016). The facade of democracy is still there, but the content is hollowed out. Germany's Weimar Republic offers a historical precedent: democracy can be legally destroyed from within. Hitler's 1933 Enabling Act abolished parliamentary rule by parliamentary process (Ziblatt, 2025).

Contemporary Hungary shows similar mechanisms in a modern context. Viktor Orbán used his parliamentary supermajority gained in the 2010 election to rewrite the constitution, pack the courts, consolidate media ownership, and redraw electoral boundaries. He did this through legal means and without disruption to elections (Norberg, 2026). As legal scholar Kim Lane Scheppele describes it, this was "legal but not legitimate" (Scheppele, 2012). The procedures of democracy were preserved while its competitive substance was systematically removed. The democratic crisis in this example is driven by the transformation of institutions into instruments of control.

The pattern of executive overreach that Bermeo (2016) identifies is visible in recent US electoral policy too. Donald Trump's Safeguard American Voter Eligibility Act, commonly called the "SAVE Act," seeks to make voting more restrictive, which will disenfranchise around nine percent of voters from exercising their constitutional right to vote (Wang & Clement &Sidhom, 2026). As Martinez and Rummler (2026) report, further provisions include voter ID requirements and a ban on mail-in ballots. There may exist some instances of

voting fraud, but they have not been proven to be pervasive. In any case, such measures risk pre-emptively tilting the electoral playing field, reinforcing partisan advantage, and weakening the principle that elections should be free, fair, and competitive. It is telling that the SAVE Act passed the House of Representatives and only stalled in the Senate: the institutional appetite for restricting democratic participation is present at the highest levels of government.

Attacks on the media are following the same pattern. The Pentagon's attempt to introduce a new press credential policy, struck down by a federal judge for violating the First Amendment, made clear that the policy has been designed to replace critical journalists with more compliant reporters (Pellish, 2026). Similarly, attempts to defund major public broadcasters such as the National Public Radio and Public Broadcasting System reflect a broader strategy of constraining independent media not by abolishing it, but by limiting its capacity. That courts have blocked several of these measures matters, but so does the fact that they were attempted at all. The significance of executive aggrandizement lies not only in what succeeds but in what is normalized through the attempt.

**Shifting Geopolitics**

The third dynamic operates from outside: the external constraints that once raised the cost of backsliding have weakened. The American case assumes further significance because of its knock-on effects on the rest of the world. As Levitsky and Way (2010) put, the US has functioned as the primary source of 'democratic leverage'. In other words, the US has exerted diplomatic, economic and military pressure to constrain fragile democracies around the world from backsliding.

In the wake of the collapse of the Soviet Union, US governmental bodies such as the U.S. Agency for International Development (USAID), the State Department, the U.S. Agency for Global Media (parent of Voice of America and Radio Free Europe/Radio Liberty), and the National Endowment for Democracy (NED) were central to America's efforts to maintain democratic standards globally. Lithuania, Latvia, and Estonia are success stories. Democracy consolidated itself these states gained admission to NATO and the EU. As American credibility erodes, so does the leverage it once provided. The United States is not only a domestic case of institutional capture but a primary reason the geopolitical environment now permits greater backsliding. The retreat leaves a vacuum, and that vacuum is being actively filled.

As Larry Diamond (2015) argues, the world is experiencing a democratic recession because authoritarian powers are actively exporting their model as a legitimate form of governance. China and Russia offer varying forms of authoritarian value propositions: the promise of stability, economic development, and sovereignty from Western interference, without the inconvenient requirements of democratic reform (Li, 2013). China offers infrastructure investment with no democratic conditionality attached as part of its Belt and Road Initiative (Dezenski, 2020). Russia, through networks like RT and Sputnik, attempts not simply to spread pro-Kremlin narratives but to provoke broader distrust and civil unrest across the Western world by fanning the flames of latent domestic tensions across nations (Wagnsson, 2023). The culmination of this is an atmosphere of geopolitical permissiveness: an environment in which democratic backsliding carries fewer consequences and authoritarian consolidation carries diminishing stigma.

**Optimism**

Democratic backsliding is not inevitable, despite these trends. South Korea and Brazil stand as valuable cases of democracies surviving sustained attacks. At the time, their democracies were eulogised, but today we might more accurately categorise their recent histories as

periods of stress-testing, in which institutions are challenged but not necessarily defeated. The key determining factor is not simply the presence of pressure or exposure of wrongdoing, but whether institutions respond effectively. In Brazil, democratic norms were significantly strained under Jair Bolsonaro, who repeatedly attacked electoral legitimacy, media institutions, and political opponents (V-Dem, 2022). But its institutions proved resilient, and when Bolsonaro lost a free and fair election in 2022, he was successfully removed from power despite a coup attempt. Likewise, South Korea has seen two impeachments in the last decade, and both have been successfully carried out with no autocratic seizure of power (Chira, 2025).

Democratic survival, then, depends on the strength of institutions. Where they are afraid or unable to act, democracy dies. Where they confidently intervene, it lives on. Independent judicial action is one example: necessary for democratic stability, but not sufficient on its own. Democratic backsliding is a real and significant trend; it is not irreversible. Brazil and South Korea held because their judiciaries acted, but also because the international community was watching. Through this combination of robust internal mechanisms and a watchful, sincere international community, democracy can endure.

**Conclusion**

Democracy is in crisis, but not the crisis mainstream pundits identify. Bermeo's backsliding framework assumed that liberal constitutionalism and democratic self-government were inseparable; however Hungary, Turkey, and the United States demonstrates that they are not. Brazil and South Korea do not overturn this conclusion. They confirm it. Their institutions held not merely because judges were brave, but because the demos still wanted the liberal order those judges defended; the same sovereignty that rescued liberalism in Brasília is the sovereignty that dismantled it in Budapest. That is the uncomfortable terminus of the argument: liberalism's survival is contingent on a democratic choice that can go either way. Rather, the question facing liberals is therefore no longer simply how to defend democracy from authoritarians. It is actions taken when democracy itself chooses to discard liberalism. This is the fork the word crisis originally named — two paths diverging, only one leading back to the liberal order.

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